

Nice Mice

In today's GUI-dominated computing environment, a pointing device is a critical component of every system. The most popular pointing device by far is the ubiquitous mouse, followed by trackballs, touch pads, stylus pens, etc. Mice and trackballs constitute the majority of pointing devices sold. For trackballs, the main difference is in the usage—here, the pointing device is stationary while the users move the large ball mounted on the device.

The biggest players originate from Taiwan and China and their success is based upon low prices. The price range for mice starts at about Rs 300 and goes up to Rs 3,000 for higher-end models from Logitech and Microsoft. While the principle of operation of these devices is similar, the functionality (number of buttons, control surfaces and accuracy) is what determines the eventual cost.

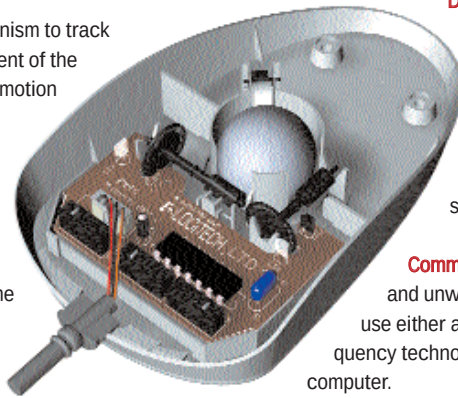
TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT

Most mice use a roller-ball mechanism to track the horizontal and vertical movement of the mouse. Some mice use an optical motion tracking mechanism that uses a beam of light reflected off the mouse surface instead of the ball.

SMART TIPS

Buttons: All mice today have at least two buttons, while some come with either a third button or with a 'wheel' which is very useful for scrolling through documents or Web pages.

Resolution: This measures how precisely your pointing device will move in response to a movement and is measured in dots per inch (dpi). Average mice have dpi ratings of about 400 dpi while precision mice have dpi ratings all the way up to 4000 dpi.



Drivers: Some of the better mice or trackballs come with special functionality built into their drivers. You get special features like zooming and scrolling, which can make life a lot simpler.

Communication: There are wired and unwired mice. The unwired mice use either an infrared sensor or radio frequency technology to communicate with the computer.

Interface: There are three interfaces available: serial port, PS/2 and USB port. Check that you have the right ports on your computer before buying a pointing device. Preferably, opt for a PS/2 or a USB device as these are easy to configure and support higher sampling frequencies.

Also Remember...

■ Sampling frequency is a specification that decides the frequency with which the mouse is 'polled' for activity—the more often it is polled, the greater is the effective smoothness of the mouse. While most mice operate on a sampling frequency of 40 Hz, smooth mice would have a sampling frequency of 100 Hz.

■ Be sure to try out the device before buying it as there are some devices that are made only for right-handed users. A left-handed user would find it very uncomfortable when used for extended periods.

	Basic functionality	Precision work	Specialised (gaming, professional imaging)
You need	A simple mouse for day-to-day work with no special stress on precision	A precision pointing device that is smooth and has decent features	Good response times, precision and smoothness of movement
Look for	A PS/2 or a serial mouse that features at least two buttons	A PS/2 or USB mouse with three buttons and the ability for scrolling within applications	A high dpi rating, perhaps an optical mouse. Go in for a PS/2 or a USB mouse or trackball
Our pick	Logitech First Mouse	Logitech Universal Scroll Mouse, Microsoft Mouse	Microsoft Intellimouse Eye, Razor Boomslang
Price range	Rs 350 to Rs 500	Rs 500 to Rs 1,000	Rs 2,500 upwards

